

transported across the placenta, so levels in your baby's blood are always higher than those in your blood.

ASK A DOCTOR

When can my baby first suck their thumb? Ultrasound scans have shown unborn babies sucking their thumbs from as early as 12–14 weeks of pregnancy. However, this is likely to be a reflex at this stage as the brain does not have any conscious control over movement until the fetus is much more developed later on in pregnancy.

Some research has suggested that if an unborn baby shows a preference for sucking, for example, their right thumb, then they will prefer to lie with their head turned to the right after the birth. The same research suggested that this preference could be used to predict right- or left-handedness in the baby as they grow older.